FOREWORD

LIKE ALL great discoveries, it started with a need.

We were in a tri-series in Kenya in 1996. Mushtaq Ahmed, our dependable World Cup champion leg spinner, was injured. So here we were, stuck in Africa, in dire need of a leggie, and in comes this kid, kind of chubby but straight-edged and quiet. None of us had heard of him before.

The selectors had picked him with some sense of hope. They said he was all right. We were like, 'Okay, sure … why not? He might work out.' But at the time, he was an unknown resource. Almost unnoticeable.

When he arrived in Nairobi and began bowling in the nets, I remember he came at us hard and fast. He had variety. He was a teenager, very agile. I remember he had a solid googly, a good faster one, and could change it up quite effortlessly. Instinctively, his bowling was less Mushtaq Ahmed and more Anil Kumble. Could have been taller, I remember telling myself.

Then came the time for him to bat. It was beginning to get dark. There wasn't much light left. He was the only one who hadn't batted. We were in a hurry to get back to the hotel. It wouldn't have been a major loss – bowlers never got to bat much in the nets in those days. What the hell, I thought, and asked him to pad up.

What happened next didn't let us make it to the hotel in time. First, I started bowling him leg-breaks. I was firmly dispatched. Next, Waqar (Younis) started bowling off-breaks to him. His deliveries too were smacked, viciously. Then, both Waqar and I tried bowling at him with a short run-up. Both of us were sent packing.

I was still sceptical. Clearly this was a *tuqqa*, a lucky strike. So we took longer run-ups and came hard at him. The kid just kept hitting us all over. The harder we came at him, the more confidently he struck the ball. Not once did he seem to flinch. Nor did he break into a sweat. He hit us for sixes in the dark, like he had night vision or something. Soon I decided to call it off. This was getting embarrassing.

The next day I told him to pad up early. This time, right from ball one, Waqar and I came at him with a full run-up. But the kid was relentless. He hit us harder than he had the previous evening. I remember thinking that the sort of shots he was hammering, had it not been for the nets, the ball would have gone out of the stadium.

It was on that day in the nets that it became clear to me: there was talent. This boy had the potential to go places.

But then news came in of my father having suffered a heart attack. As I was packing to fly back to Lahore, I suggested to Saeed Anwar, who was to captain in my absence, to let the kid bat up the order.